

broker would be looking to sell a similar lot, and I would buy it off him to square up my position.

AS-PS were curious to know whom I was sourcing shares from or selling to, and asked their lackeys to keep track of me in the ring. Owl (I named him so because of his saucer-shaped eyes) was one such jobber who owed his existence to the duo and was forever ready to carry out their bidding.

Most brokers of any significance had hotlines on the trading floor. This helped their office convey clients' orders and also helped other brokers or jobbers reach out to them with a deal. After I struck a large deal – by my standards – on the floor, I would call up the concerned broker on his hotline and ask him if he was interested in trading with me.

Once Owl and I were competing on the same stock. I bought a sizeable chunk at a good price, and then called the office of a broker who I knew was interested in that stock. The dealer at that broker's office asked me to call back in fifteen minutes while he checked with his boss. When I called back after fifteen minutes, the dealer said he was not interested. I found it a bit odd because I knew for certain that the broker had been scouting around for the stock. But I did not give much thought to the incident. When I casually mentioned this to a fellow jobber, he told me that he had seen Owl call on the same hotline shortly after I had made my call. It was only then that I realized Owl was keeping tabs on the brokers I was talking to. I am sure he would have passed on the details to his masters who then offered a better quote to those brokers and snatched the deal from me.

I had to be careful the next time, but before that I decided to have some fun at Owl's expense. I found a chance a couple of days later. I had bought a block of Dr Reddy's Laboratories and knew a broker who would be interested in it. But I did not call the broker straight away. I first picked up a couple of hotlines at random and got the dealers at the other end worked up by talking some arbitrary stuff. Owl could not hear what I was saying but presumed that I was trying to offload the Dr Reddy's shares to those brokers. I knew that Owl would ring those brokers the moment I hung up on them. But I wanted to know how Owl would react when he realized he had called up the wrong brokers. By then I had become friendly with a jobber named Prakash, a couple of years older than I, who agreed to eavesdrop on Owl for me. Sure enough, when I left after my calls, Owl walked up to the hotline, probably relishing the thought of stealing another deal from me. He